

Practice Paper 17 — Answer Scheme

Paper 2 — Comprehension

Sections B & C

Note to teachers and students

- Marks are awarded for **meaning**, not for exact words. Where a quotation is required, it has been indicated in inverted commas.
- Where the question asks for **own words**, a candidate who lifts directly from the text receives **zero** for that mark unless the lifted phrase is unavoidable.
- For language and tone questions, accept any reasonable alternative that clearly fits the textual evidence.

Section B — Text 3 Answer Scheme [20 marks]

Q1. [2] — The suitcase like “a patient, well-behaved animal”

1 mark for identifying that the suitcase is **personified** / made to seem alive.

1 mark for explaining that this makes the suitcase appear **quiet, obedient and waiting**, suggesting that the mother has prepared it very carefully and that it is patiently awaiting the journey ahead.

Sample answer: The comparison gives the suitcase a **gentle, almost living quality** — it sits quietly and obediently by the door, as if it has been **trained to wait**, which underlines how meticulously and tenderly the mother has packed it.

Q2. [1] — Why the narrator was “unsettled”

1 mark for any one reasonable inference, such as:

- The ribbon implies the mother fears she may **struggle to recognise or claim her own bag**, a small sign of her **fragility**.
- It reminds the narrator that she is **travelling alone** to a country far away.
- The smallness of the request reveals how **uncertain** she is, which forces him to confront her **ageing**.

Q3. [2] — Mother’s character

1 mark — She is **modest** / **self-effacing**: she does not openly ask for help.

1 mark — She is also quietly **manipulative in a gentle way** / understands her son well: she refuses politely while really wanting him to insist, showing a **subtle, knowing nature**. (Also accept: **proud but loving, humble**.)

Q4. [2] — Handbag like “a small, frightened pet”

1 mark — The simile gives the handbag **life and emotion**, transferring the mother's **nervousness** onto the object.

1 mark — It suggests that the mother is herself **anxious and protective**, holding the bag close in the way one would shield a **vulnerable creature**, even though she sits “very straight” and appears outwardly composed.

Q5. [2] — Repeated questions

(a) [1]: The questions were not really meant to gather information — they were a way of **managing his own nervousness / channelling his anxiety** into something practical, since he had already been told the answers many times.

(b) [1]: It suggests his **deep love and tenderness** for his mother — he wants to **comfort and touch** her, but as a grown son he cannot easily express that affection directly, so the questions become a **substitute** for holding her hand.

Q6. [3] — Argument about the route (language question)

1 mark for identifying that the disagreement is really about **something deeper** — the mother's awareness that she may not have many more chances / the son's reluctance to face this.

1 mark each for any **two** clearly quoted and explained details (max 2):

- “one did not... get many more chances to see the sea from a car at six in the morning” — a quiet acknowledgement of her **mortality / advancing age**.
- “I did not trust my voice to say anything sensible” — the son is **fighting tears / too emotional to speak**, showing the moment matters more than the route.
- “she watched it with the open, undemanding attention of a child” — the mother is **savouring** the view as though for the **last time**.
- “I drove, without speaking, to the next exit, and turned off” — he yields **immediately and silently**, as though understanding her unspoken meaning.

Each detail must be **quoted** and **explained**; mere lifting without explanation = ½ mark.

Q7. [2] — Mother's hidden anxiety

1 mark each for any two of:

- She has packed **only what she could lift herself** (control / not wanting to feel helpless).
- The aunt's address is written out **three times in three different inks**, in case one copy is lost.
- She has packed **boiled sweets** (a small comfort item).
- She has prepared a **sealed envelope to her late husband**, suggesting she is preparing for the possibility of **not returning**.

Q8. [1] — Effect of the dashes

1 mark — The dashes create a **sudden pause / aside** that **interrupts** the flow of the sentence and **highlights** the emotionally weighty information that the father has been dead for nine years; they slow the reader down and add a sense of **quiet shock**. (Also accept: they suggest the narrator's own hesitation in revealing this detail.)

Q9. [2] — Mother “much smaller than I remembered her being”

1 mark — The narrator is **seeing his mother as physically frail / shrunk** by age — her body has changed in a way he had not properly registered until now.

1 mark — It also marks a **role-reversal / shift in his perception**: he no longer sees her as the strong protective figure of his childhood, but as someone **vulnerable** who needs **his** protection.

Q10. [2] — Effect of repeating “the same hand”

1 mark — The **repetition** emphasises the **exactness of the memory** and creates emotional **intensity**; it shows the narrator is suddenly overwhelmed by a **vivid childhood recollection**.

1 mark — It also collapses **time** — the moment at the airport and the first day of school become **one and the same gesture**, underlining the **unchanging love** of the mother despite her ageing body.

Q11. [1] — Tone of the final sentence

1 mark — Any **one** of: **quietly grieving, resigned, tender, sorrowful, reverent, bittersweet**. (Reject: **angry, bitter, happy** — these miss the subdued, mournful quality.)

Section C — Text 4 Answer Scheme [25 marks]

Q12. [2] — “A kind of secular rite of passage”

1 mark for understanding **rite of passage** — an **important life event** that **marks the move from one stage of life to another** (childhood to adulthood).

1 mark for understanding **secular** — **non-religious**, treated as a **cultural rather than sacred** milestone; together, leaving home was an **expected, almost ceremonial step** into adulthood.

Q13. [2] — “Simply the generation”

1 mark — Living at home as an adult was once unusual enough to attract **mocking media attention** (the term “boomerang generation” was a **novelty / curiosity**).

1 mark — Today it is **no longer the exception but the norm** — so widespread that it now describes **most** young adults, not a small subset.

Q14. [2] — Economic reasons

1 mark each for any two of:

- House prices have risen **much faster than young people’s wages** (37% vs 4%).
- Rents in major cities **consume more than half** of a young worker’s take-home pay.
- The cost of independent living has become **mathematically impossible** even for educated, employed young people.

Q15. [1] — Writer’s attitude

1 mark — **Sympathetic / understanding / non-judgemental**. The writer sees their decision as a **rational and reasonable response** to economic reality, not as laziness or failure. (Also accept: **defensive of them**. Reject: **critical, mocking**.)

Q16. [2] — “Would have struck their own parents as eccentric”

1 mark — Earlier generations **expected** their children to leave home in early adulthood and would have considered it **strange** / unusual to want them to stay.

1 mark — In contrast, today’s parents are **much more relaxed and welcoming** about adult children remaining — showing a **generational softening** of family expectations.

Reject answers that simply lift “eccentric” without rewording.

Q17. [3] — Milan vs Seoul

(a) [1]: The inverted commas mark the phrases as **labels used by different societies** — they are **not the writer’s own words** but the **terms each culture uses** to describe the same situation. (Also accept: they show that the writer is **distancing himself** and treating these phrases as **judgements**, not facts.)

(b) [2]: **1 mark** — The contrast shows that the **same living arrangement** is interpreted **very differently** depending on **cultural context**.

1 mark — In Asia, where multigenerational living was traditional, young adults staying is now

sometimes seen as a **problem**, whereas in Europe, where independence was the norm, it is now being recast as **positive closeness** — suggesting that the **meaning** of the arrangement is shaped more by **geography and tradition** than by the arrangement itself.

Q18. [2] — “Helps most when it is chosen, and harms most when it is endured” (own words)

1 mark — Living with parents **benefits** young adults when they have **freely decided** to do so and feel comfortable with the arrangement.

1 mark — It **damages** their well-being when they feel **forced** to stay against their will / have no real alternative, leading to feelings of being **stuck** in life.

Reject answers that lift “chosen” or “endured” without rewording.

Q19. [2] — Cities adapting

1 mark each for any two of:

- Town planners are **redesigning flats** for **three-generation households** rather than just couples and small families.
- Demand for “**multi-key**” apartments — units with **two front doors and a shared kitchen** — has risen sharply in Singapore and Tokyo.
- Builders in Sydney are marketing “**granny flats**” to **grown-up sons** rather than grandparents.
- Businesses that depended on young renters (cafes, furniture shops) are **rethinking their assumptions** / changing their target customers.

Q20. [2] — Purpose of offering two readings

1 mark — It shows the writer is being **balanced and fair-minded** / refusing to oversimplify a complex social trend.

1 mark — It allows the reader to **weigh both interpretations** — the hopeful and the bleak — and acknowledges that **both contain truth**, which makes the argument feel **more credible and thoughtful**.

Q21. [1] — Tone of “call its captivity by softer names”

1 mark — Any **one** of: **bitter, cynical, sardonic, critical, darkly ironic**. (Reject: **neutral, hopeful, playful** — these miss the sharp, accusing quality.)

Q22. Summary [13 marks total: 6 content + 7 style]

Content points (½ mark each, max 6 marks). **Eight available content points; candidates should aim for all 8.**

Reasons young adults stay (Paragraphs 2–4):

1. Housing prices have **risen far faster than wages**, making property unaffordable.
2. Rents **consume more than half** of a young worker’s earnings in major cities.
3. Parents today are **more welcoming** of adult children remaining at home.
4. In Asian societies, multigenerational living was **always normal**, not a sign of failure.

Consequences for individuals and cities (Paragraphs 5–6):

5. Those who live with supportive parents report **less loneliness and better sleep**.

6. A significant minority feel **developmentally stuck** / unable to reach adult milestones.
7. Town planners are designing **multi-generational flats** and “multi-key” apartments.
8. Businesses that **depended on young renters** (cafes, cheap furniture) must **rethink their customer base**.

Sample full-marks summary (78 words):

Many young adults remain in the family home partly because property prices have outstripped wages and city rents now swallow over half their pay. Parents are also more willing to host them, and in Asia such arrangements were always normal. The effects are mixed: those who stay willingly report less loneliness and better rest, but many feel their adulthood has stalled. Cities, meanwhile, are redesigning flats for three generations, while shops dependent on young renters must reinvent themselves.

Length count: 78 words from “Many” onwards.

— END OF ANSWER SCHEME —